Andropov
August 4, 1983

There was a handwritten postscript at the bottom of Andropov's letter:

> I sincerely hope, Mr. President, that you will give serious consideration to the thoughts I have expressed and that you will be able to respond to them in a constructive spirit.

The letter made me more certain than ever that we had to go ahead with plans to deploy the new intermediate-range NATO missiles in Europe, because once that threat was removed, the Soviets wouldn't have any reason to eliminate their INF weapons.

This was my reply to Andropov:

Dear Mr. Chairman:

> Thank you for your letter which was conveyed to me on August 5. I have of course given it my most serious attention and welcome the assurances of your commitment to finding solutions to the problems that confront us. I can see that we both recognize the awesome responsibility history has placed on our shoulders to guide the two most powerful countries in the world in this difficult and dangerous period.
>
> I agree with you that, if we are to make progress in our joint endeavor, we cannot bypass important issues merely because they are difficult. I also agree that our attention must be directed above all to the central issue of consolidating security in the world.
>
> In my view, this central issue has three key aspects: first, the vital need for the world to move toward the principle of settling international disputes by peaceful